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two-hour train ride from Mumbai. This small city in Gujarat with a population of 160,000 people once used to be in the news for its worrying pollution levels. More than that, the city is also known for its enterprising business community with high levels of disposable income. But like in many non-metro cities of India, that money is not always visible.

About a year ago, the management of Saint-Gobain India caught a glimpse of this wealth when they received a request for a quote from an individual in the city for doing up his home. The requirement included shower enclosures, doors and slid-

ing shutters, among other fitments, and the amount to be spent was a not-so-small ₹20 lakh.

Narrating the story, B. Santhanam, CEO of Saint-Gobain, Asia-Pacific and India Region, and Chairman of the Indian business, says that the company's foray into the B2C (business-to-consumer) space was driven by an opportunity observed in the home improvement segment coupled with its own strengths in the areas of designing, manufacturing and distributing various home improvement products. Apart from Saint-Gobain India, the group's only unlisted entity in India, its operations also include Grindwell Norton and Saint-Gobain Sekurit India—all operating in the B2B (business-to-business) space. Now, a strategy to get a chunk of the B2C market in India by way of home improvement solutions is underway. The group currently provides solutions in the form of products such as windows, shower cubicles, kitchen and wardrobe shutters, ceilings and roofing products and mirrors, among others.

Across its three companies in India, the revenue for the current calendar year is expected to be ₹12,000

crore. The target for 2030 is set at ₹30,000 crore, which will be a steep 2.5x jump on an already large base. Today, just 5 per cent of the group's revenue comes from the B2C business, and on a larger revenue base, that proportion will increase too.

SOUNDS LIKE A PLAN

Sitting in his office at the company's World Glass Complex (WGC) located in Sriperumbudur that is about an hour's drive from Chennai, Santhanam speaks of how the need to get into consumers' homes was an idea conceived around a decade ago. A company lifer (he joined Grindwell Norton in 1980 before it was acquired by Saint-Gobain in 1996), he outlines the challenge quite succinctly when he says, "We knew it had to be done but did not know how to go about it."

The sprawling campus, spread across 177 acres on the Chennai-Bengaluru highway, provides an interesting backdrop for this conversation, interspersed by the chirping of birds. The French major, with a global turnover of over €44 billion, has put in place robust facilities for rainwater harvesting and other sustainable measures. With a



POLISHED TO A SHINE

① At least 80 per cent of India's real estate market is residential

② The home improvement market in India is worth \$30 billion

③ Over 95 per cent of that is unorganised in nature

④ Saint-Gobain is looking to be a solutions provider to get a chunk of the home improvement market

⑤ The company believes its revenues can grow by 2.5x from here